

DISTANT PROXIMITY
Ex-CM Raje and PM Modi at a BJP rally in Jodhpur, Oct. 5

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EX-CM RAJE'S INVOLVEMENT WILL BE A CRUCIAL FACTOR IN HOW THE BJP PERFORMS. EVEN THE *SATTA* BAZAAR IS BASING ITS ODDS ON THIS

Congress in 2018 and whom he has kept happy. But then he also keeps visiting Hindu temples, pre-empting the BJP charge of minority appeasement or of being anti-Hindu.

The looming presence of Modi is a new challenge, although the concomitant diminution of ex-CM and arch-rival Vasundhara Raje—who has defeated Gehlot twice in the past—comes as a breather. She will be a crucial factor in how the BJP performs—even the underground *satta* (betting) market is basing the odds on how many seats the BJP can win with Raje, and how many without her. So Gehlot keeps asking in his speeches whether Modi will come to rule Rajasthan as chief minister if the BJP wins and, if not, who among the contenders will it be (the party has got seven MPs in the first list of 41 contestants). He has been blowing up the BJP's internal feuds at rallies, pointing to how Modi's dislike for Raje resulted in the state losing out on projects in her previous tenure.

The CM has also gone all-out to make the Eastern River Canal Project (ERCP), aimed at channelling the monsoon-surplus water from rivers such as the Chambal in the south to 13 southeastern districts into a major election issue. Gehlot is even planning a yatra through the region on October 16 to blame Modi for the project not taking off. Eastern Rajasthan is a Congress stronghold and if ERCP becomes an emotive issue, the party will go to the polls with at least 30 seats for sure.

About the BJP campaign so far, Barmer-based political observer Amit Rakesh says, "The Modi-Amit Shah duo can always pull out a miracle, but the BJP should let Raje lead the campaign with some good second-rung leaders. The party's poll teams looks rudderless now." Indeed, sidelining Raje and hoping the MPs and Union ministers pulled in to fight the poll will carry the day is a big gamble. The campaign focus is on these lines now—the 'Modi is BJP' idea; highlighting the rise in crime, corruption and shortage of basic amenities; and Gehlot reneging on the farm loan waiver promise.

The OBC votes will also be a major factor. The CM has declared that there will be a caste-based census with an increase in reservation for OBCs if the Congress gets a new term. Gehlot himself is an OBC but has so far not been able to channel the community votes as a block, but this is an opportunity. The party high command will use Pilot to retain the Gujjar vote bank and Gehlot has also tried to ingratiate himself to the Jats. The CM has so far refrained from trying to gain voter sympathy by projecting this election as his last battle. But as the polls near, he'll need that extra boost to get a place in the history books as the one who turned the tide in the Rajasthan election. ■